disturbances took their toll on the Qaitul Buddhist monastic complex, abandoned by the eighth century without any scope for revival.[84] During the same time frame, if not before, Old Qandahar had also contracted to a shadow of its former self. By the mid-twelfth century and the likely Shansabani presence there, the site's status was even more uncertain, having experienced a pronounced decline in settled mercantile and associated occupation over several centuries, though nomadic populations likely continued visitations to the area. Later eleventh- and twelfth-century Persian texts mentioned a certain Tiginabad in the same region, probably referring to Old Qandahar's later iteration as a settlement of greatly reduced size.[85] In fact, Juzjani implicitly confirmed the identification of Old Qandahar as at least in the vicinity of Tiginabad, if not the same settlement, in the context of the Shansabanis' sacking of Ghazna and Lashkari Bazar in AH 545/1150 CE.[86] But it should be noted that Tiginabad/Old Qandahar's diminution in both size and importance between the eighth and fifteenth centuries is remarkable given its location, which had rendered the entire area "at *all* times in its history … a major frontier stronghold of immense strategic value."[87]

Given Tiginabad/Old Qandahar's minor status by the mid-twelfth century (and earlier), the reasons behind a Shansabani campaign and/or presence there, along with the nature and duration of their stay during initial expansion outside their ancestral Ghur, may seem less than apparent.[88] However, the skirmishes over the site between the Ghazna Yaminis and the Shansabanis highlight not only its importance for the continuing power struggle in the region, the *Firuzkuh* Shansabanis' ultimate victory in capturing it further reveal the politico-economic differences between this branch and their Bamiyan cousins. Certainly, Tiginabad/Old Qandahar's location between Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar made it much more strategically relevant to the Shansabanis of Firuzkuh than to their cousins at Bamiyan. In AH 552/1158 CE,[89] 'Ala' al-Din Husain once again confronted Ghaznavid forces and wrested the locale, interrupting the Yamini transit corridor between Ghazna and al-Rukkhaj-Zamindawar.[90] Moreover, the discernible post-conquest "footprint" at Tiginabad/Old Qandahar seems to reflect a distinctly Firuzkuh Shansabani character, rather than one evoking their palace-dwelling Bamiyan relatives.

The above-mentioned excavations at Tiginabad/Old Qandahar during the 1970s unearthed an extensive cemetery – surprisingly vast, in fact, with an extent surpassing the settlement itself.[91] The cemetery contained burials largely following Islamic prescriptions, that is, north–south placement of unburned bodies with faces oriented toward Mecca – the *qibla* being in a westerly direction from South Asia – within graves devoid of any goods buried with the deceased. Among the burials, two large mounds, which the archaeologists referred to as Mound A and Mound B, were visible and even prominent features of the landscape calling for excavation.